

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1989-06-22

1 dear bahá'í friends,
2 pressing its concern about the conditions existing within your Assembly 65.1
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68 message from The Universal House of Justice
69 128and asking for views and recommendations to be sent to it by members of
70 the National Spiritual Assembly individually. A number of responses have
71 been received, along with additional information requested by the house
72 of justice from other sources. we have been directed to convey to you the
73 following.
74 one of the distinctive features of the bahá'í Administrative order, which
75 stands in striking contrast to the administrative systems associated with past
76 dispensations, is the responsibility it places upon the individual believer to
77 participate in its activities. in contrast to the members of congregations of
78 many other religions whose role is principally that of being the recipients
79 of instruction and advice from their ecclesiastical leaders, the followers of
80 bahá'u'lláh are called upon, in their relationships within the community, to
81 engage in consultation, to follow closely the affairs of the faith in their re-
82 gion, to offer their views and recommendations on all matters which pertain to the
interests of the faith and its community, and to elect the Spiritual
83 Assemblies and cooperate wholeheartedly with them. This active involvement by
every bahá'í in the life of the community provides it with access
84 to each individual's insight and wisdom and is a source of great strength to the
organic unit.
membership on an Assembly imposes upon the believer the spiritual re-
85 sponsibility to become an active participant in its work, to be fully informed
86 of its endeavors, and to ensure that its functioning is in accord with bahá'í

87 principles. every Assembly member should recognize that he has a duty to
88 ensure that his voice is heard and that appropriate consideration is given to his views.
'Abdu'l-b ahá has stated that consultation succeeds in avoiding "ill-
89 feeling or discord" when "every member expresseth with absolute freedom
90 his own opinion and setteth forth his argument," with the further affirma-tion by the
guardian that "it is not only the right but the sacred obligation
91 of every member to express freely and openly his views, without being afraid of
displeasing or alienating any of his fellow members," and "The Assembly members must
have the courage of their convictions, but must also express wholehearted and unqualified
obedience to the well considered judgment

and directions of the majority of their fellow members."

92 67-1

93 67-1. Sw Ab, no. 44; cc 2:1380.67 .2

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69 129No member of an Assembly should feel inhibited from participating in
70 the consultation because of what he may believe to be deficiencies in his
71 education, experience or knowledge of the faith. rather he should rely
72 with unshakeable faith on the divine confirmations which will bestow wis-
73 dom and guidance upon the sincere believer who approaches his assigned functions
in a spirit of consecration and humility, beseeching the aid of
74 the omniscient lord. he should also be guided by the observation of the
75 guardian: "Not infrequently, nay oftentimes, the most lowly, untutored
76 and inexperienced among the friends will, by the sheer inspiring force of
77 selfless and ardent devotion, contribute a distinct and memorable share to a

highly involved discussion in any given assembly."

78 67-2

79 if an Assembly member feels that there are barriers affecting the consulta-
80 tion of the body, he should frankly and courageously raise his concerns; these
barriers could include, for example, the consultation moving at a
81 speed which confuses him, language being used which he cannot under-stand,
behavioral characteristics which unwittingly express condescension leading to the
humiliation of others, or a feeling that one is being ignored.

82 Such barriers may well arise as the faith continues its inexorable progress

83 in creating dynamic consultative bodies which bring together, in a spirit
 84 of unity and equality, the historically divided elements of humanity, thus laying the
 foundation for a new and ever advancing civilization.
 85 it is the responsibility of all members of an Assembly to ensure that its
 86 officers are elected properly, function correctly and discharge their duties in
 accordance with the decisions of the Assembly. if a member feels, for
 87 example, that the meetings are not chaired effectively, that the minutes are not an
 accurate report of the decisions made at the meeting, or that the correspondence of the
 secretary or the financial transactions carried out by the treasurer do not conform to the
 instructions of the Assembly, he should
 88 bring this matter up at the Assembly meeting, taking care to ensure that this
 89 is done with appropriate moderation, courtesy and balance.
 90 your Assembly to improve the quality of your consultation and the effec-
 91 tiveness of your functioning. it requests you to ensure that copies of this
 92 letter are provided to each member of the Assembly, and that translations
 93 are provided if any individual members of the Assembly feel that this would
 94 67-2. bA, p. 79.67 .4
 67 .5
 67 .6
 67 .7
 68 m e S a g e f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
 69 10facilitate their understanding of it. when all members have had an opportu-
 70 nity to study the letter, you should arrange a special session of the Assembly
 71 for consultation on its contents. you may also wish to seek the advice of the
 72 counselors on measures to be taken to carry out more fully its provisions.
 73 with loving b ahá'í greetings,

Department of tHe secretariat

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The Importance of Literacy

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]